Where the Snap Fails

The Real Numbers as Counterexample

ZP-F Companion | Initial: May 2026 | Current: 1.15, October 2026

This companion document is written for general readers. It explains in plain language why the real number line cannot serve as the mathematical substrate for the Binary Snap, and why the 2-adic metric Q_2 is required. The formal results are machine-verified in Lean 4 as part of ZP-F (F-SNAP-IMPOSSIBLE and the general ordered field result); see also ZP-B (p-adic topology) for the positive case.

I. The Natural Question

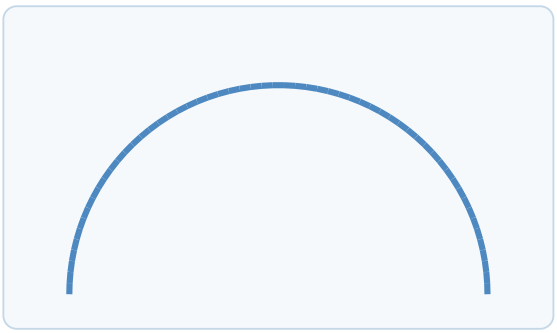
If you have read ZP-B, a natural question arises: why the 2-adic metric? Why p-adic numbers at all? The real numbers are more familiar and more widely used. They seem like the natural substrate for any framework involving continuity, limits, and state transitions. This document is the answer.

The answer begins with a counterexample. The real number line is not a valid substrate for the Binary Snap — not because it is wrong, but because it is the space where the snap is structurally impossible. Understanding why the snap fails in $\mathbb{R}$ is the clearest path to understanding why Q_2 is required.

II. The Density Symmetry

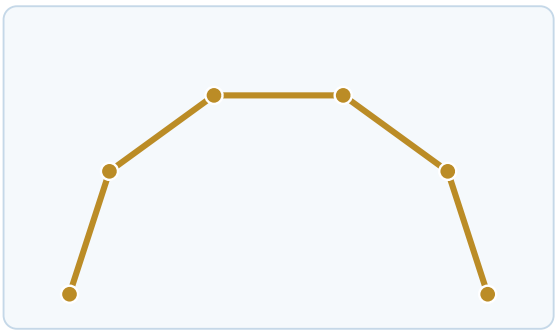
The smooth nature of the real numbers comes from the fact that between any two real numbers — no matter how close — there is always another one. This density applies uniformly: for any proposed first step $\varepsilon > 0$ away from zero, the value $\varepsilon/2$ is smaller and also positive. There is no minimal departure. The density that prevents a closest real number to zero is the same density that prevents a smallest positive real number — it works in every direction.

Zero in $\mathbb{R}$ is not a special topological location. It is an ordinary point on a continuum that looks the same from every direction. For any candidate first step $\varepsilon_0 > 0$, the number $\varepsilon_0 / 2$ also exists, and $\varepsilon_0 / 4$, and $\varepsilon_0 / 2^n$ for every n. A discrete, irreversible departure from zero — the Binary Snap — is structurally impossible in $\mathbb{R}$.



Standard scale — smooth and continuous

No first step away from zero



Zoomed in — the same arc shows discrete steps

A minimum unit of departure becomes visible

The same mathematical arc — a piece of a circle, the curve that defines π — at two sampling resolutions. At standard scale it appears smooth and continuous (left). At high zoom, discrete steps become visible (right). In the actual real numbers, the decimal expansion can always continue; the smooth curve never structurally breaks down. The snap requires a space where that breakdown is built in, not imposed.

III. Where the Infinity Lives

The distinction between $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{Q}_2$ is not a matter of degree. It is a question of where the infinity lives.

In $\mathbb{R}$, the infinity lives in the representation. An infinitely long decimal like $\pi = 3.14159\ldots$ describes a finite magnitude — a number sitting between 3 and 4. The infinite expansion is the notation, not the thing being noted. The number itself is finite and well-located on the line. Zero is a limit point: surrounded by non-zero reals, reachable as a limit but not isolated from them. That is a fact about the metric, and the 2-adic zero shares it; what rules the snap out in $\mathbb{R}$ is the order, which is dense.

In $\mathbb{Q}_2$, the infinity is the address of zero. The 2-adic valuation assigns $+\infty$ to 0 as its actual value, and no non-zero element shares it (padic_addVal_eq_top_iff); every non-zero element carries a finite integer valuation. That is the valuation chart. In the metric chart the 2-adic zero is a limit too: doubling a non-zero element over and over converges to 0 and does not reach it in finite time, while counting down in the natural numbers reaches 0 in finitely many steps (floor_reach_separates_mu_nu). $\mathbb{Q}_2$'s zero is a floor approached as a limit, not one stepped onto. Neither fact is a first step.

A geometric analogy: the Riemann sphere maps the entire complex plane onto a sphere of diameter 1, placing the origin at one pole and the point at infinity at the other. The two are antipodal — as far apart as any two points on the sphere can be. The 2-adic valuation does something structurally similar: it places zero at infinite valuation and every non-zero element at finite valuation, making zero and the rest of the number line antipodal in the valuative sense. What the Riemann sphere shows geometrically, the 2-adic valuation encodes algebraically.

$\mathbb{R}$ Real Numbers	$\mathbb{Q}_2$ 2-adic Numbers
Order: densely ordered, so no element, zero included, has a first step	Order: none supplied (Mathlib has no order instance on $\mathbb{Q}_2$), so density does not apply

Metric: 0 is a limit point of the non-zero reals	Metric: 0 is a limit point too — the doubling orbit $2^n x$ tends to 0 and does not reach it in finite time
Infinity lives in the representation (infinite decimal = finite magnitude)	Valuation: infinity is the address of 0 — $v_2(0) = +\infty$, the greatest value; every nonzero element has a finite valuation
The snap cannot occur — density blocks every candidate first step	The snap is not blocked by density, and no first step is supplied either (the step itself is AX-B1, a commitment)

IV. Finite Precision Makes the Snap Possible

Every computer already knows this. Any number system with a maximum number of decimal places — any fixed-point arithmetic system, any discretized simulation — has a smallest representable positive number — call it δ. Below that, there's nowhere to go. The density argument fails at δ. The snap becomes available: there is a genuine first step, and halving it is not possible. Whether that step is taken is a separate question, and the framework commits to it rather than deriving it.

The real numbers are the idealization in which this floor is removed — the limiting case in which precision is unbounded and the minimum disappears. That is not a feature from the perspective of the Zero Paradox. It is exactly what blocks the snap.

Q_2 is not an artificially truncated real line, and it does not restore a smallest step. Its zero is a floor of the other kind: a finite-precision system's floor is reached by counting down, while Q_2's is a limit the doubling orbit approaches and does not reach in finite time (floor_reach_separates_mu_nu), marked out by its valuation, $v_2(0) = +\infty$. The first step the snap needs is AX-B1, a commitment, not a consequence of the 2-adic structure.

> Every finite computational system is already subject to the Binary Snap by construction. The minimum representable positive value exists; the density argument fails there. The real numbers are the most familiar example of a structure that removes this floor — but any dense ordered set has the same property, including the rational numbers: for any $\varepsilon_0 > 0$, $\varepsilon_0 / 2$ also exists. Q_2 does not put a smallest step back in: its zero is a floor approached as a limit and marked by its valuation, and the step itself is AX-B1.

V. The Coach and the Players

The real number line is not wrong. It is internally consistent and extraordinarily useful for calculus, analysis, and modeling continuous change. But it cannot host the Binary Snap — not because it fails as a mathematical structure, but because of how it treats zero.

Consider a sports team. The coach and the players are not peers. The coach is not on the field, does not wear the same uniform, and cannot be substituted in. The role is categorically different — the coach is the origin and organising principle of the game, not a participant in it. You cannot return to the coach the way you move between players. That path does not exist.

Zero has the same relationship to the states above it. It is the floor from which everything departs — not a peer of the states, but their origin. In the ZP framework, zero is the asymptotic limit that the system moves

away from, not a state it can stably occupy or return to. In $\mathbb{R}$, zero has no such character: it is a regular point of a dense line, indistinguishable in structure from 1 or π, with no first step above it. The density is what disqualifies it (axb1_fails_everywhere_iff_dense); being approached as a limit is not, since the 2-adic 0 is approached as a limit too (floor_reach_separates_mu_nu).

The real number line treats zero as an ordinary point — a peer of every other element, with the same local structure as 1 or π. In $\mathbb{R}$, zero is not valuatively distinct from any other element; every point looks the same from the perspective of the metric. That is why return paths are permitted: if zero is just another player, nothing distinguishes the path back from any other movement on the line. Directionality — the one-way ratchet the framework requires — cannot be grounded in a space where zero is indistinguishable in kind from everything else.

Q_2 gives zero a genuinely different role, and it shows in two charts. In the valuation chart zero has the address $+\infty$: $v_2(0) = +\infty$, the greatest value, while every non-zero element carries a finite integer valuation, and only zero has $+\infty$ (padic_addVal_eq_top_iff). In the metric chart zero is a limit the other elements approach: the doubling orbit converges to it and does not arrive in finite time (floor_reach_separates_mu_nu). Zero is in Q_2 but it is not a peer. The coach is not on the field. The path back does not exist.

VI. Mathematical Constants and Forcing

A natural follow-on question: if infinitely long decimals are the issue, what about π itself? π is infinitely long. Does it already qualify for the incompressibility results elsewhere in the ZP framework?

No — and the reason matters. π is infinitely long in its decimal expansion, but it is computable. Finite algorithms — the Leibniz formula, the BBP algorithm, dozens of others — can generate π to any precision you specify, however large. There is no bound on the precision you can ask for. But this is the point, not a problem: the Kolmogorov complexity of the first n digits of π is tiny relative to n. The short algorithm is the information, not the infinite decimal. You can demand arbitrarily many digits; the specification of π remains short regardless.

This is what makes π a constant rather than an arbitrary number. It is the necessary consequence of a geometric relationship — the ratio of circumference to diameter — and that relationship provides the compression. The value is forced by the definition. The computability follows from the forcing. Constants are computable because they have finite definitions; the finite definition is the short program.

Most real numbers are not like this. Almost all real numbers — in the measure-theoretic sense — have no finite definition that picks them out. They are algorithmically random: no short program generates them; the first n digits have Kolmogorov complexity close to n. High algorithmic complexity is the signature of a number with no mathematical structure behind it, no definition that points to it specifically.

VII. Two Kinds of Incompressibility

This brings us to a subtle but important point. ZP-C includes the result L-INF: $\perp$ has unbounded surprisal — no finite external description can capture it. A careful reader might ask: is this the same as saying $\perp$ is algorithmically incompressible, like a random real number?

It is not. The distinction is the difference between randomness and necessity.

A random real number is incompressible because it has no structure — no mathematical relationship forces it to be what it is. Its complexity is high because it is arbitrary. Nothing points to it specifically.

⊥ is incompressible for the opposite reason: because anything standing external to it is structurally excluded. Nothing can occupy a position outside ⊥ to describe it — not because the description is too complex, but because the position of "external to ⊥" does not exist. ⊥ is not arbitrary. It is the most constrained object in the framework, the unique global minimum of the lattice. Its incompressibility is not the noise of randomness. It is the silence of structural necessity.

The real number line mixes both kinds — computable constants alongside algorithmically random reals — with no topological distinction between them. ZP-C's L-INF is a claim of an entirely different character.

The contrast in one sentence

A random real is incompressible because nothing forced it to be what it is. ⊥ is incompressible because nothing can stand outside it. One is the absence of structure. The other is structure all the way down.

VIII. Two Approaches to the Same Boundary

The density argument and the ordinal threshold argument feel like two separate observations — one about why the snap fails in ℝ, one about where it succeeds. But they are approaching the same boundary from opposite directions, and that is not a coincidence.

From the field side: density shows there is no smallest positive element in ℝ. For any candidate first step $\varepsilon > 0$, the value $\varepsilon/2$ is smaller and also positive. There is always something between any candidate step and zero, so zero has no first step. That is a fact about the order. In fact an order is dense exactly when no element at all has a first step (axb1_fails_everywhere_iff_dense), so density rules out a first step at zero; one element lacking a first step would not make an order dense. Zero in ℝ is also a limit point, a fact about the metric; so is zero in Q_2 (floor_reach_separates_mu_nu), so the limit point is not what blocks the snap.

From the ordinal side: ε_0 has no ordinal immediately below it. There is no α with $\alpha + 1 = \varepsilon_0$. It is the limit of the tower ω, ω^ω, ω^ω^ω, … — approachable from below by finite iteration, but not reachable in any finite number of steps. The snap is possible at ε_0 precisely because it has no predecessor: there is no “just before” it that the snap would have to pass through.

Both conditions describe the same structure from opposite sides. In the field case, zero has no smallest positive neighbour in ℝ — density fills the gap above zero completely. In the ordinal case, ε_0 has no immediate predecessor in the ordinals — no α with $\alpha + 1 = \varepsilon_0$ exists. The snap is the meeting point — the boundary both sides are approaching.

This is why the snap cannot be located by looking in just one direction. From inside the real numbers, you can see that density blocks something, but you cannot see ε_0 directly. From inside the ordinals, you can see the limit ordinal structure, but not the 2-adic topology. Neither framework alone is enough. The snap is precisely the point where each framework runs out of its own descriptive reach — which means you need both frameworks, approaching from their respective directions, to pin it down.

Mathematicians call this pattern the squeeze — the same idea behind the squeeze theorem in calculus, where two functions approaching a limit from above and below force the middle to the same point. Here the squeeze is not an optional proof technique. It is the only way to locate the snap, because the snap is the point where each framework runs out of its own descriptive reach.

The Minimal Required Structure

The real numbers are the most natural, most familiar metric space in mathematics. They are also precisely the space where the Binary Snap cannot occur. They are densely ordered, so no element, zero included, has a first step: every candidate first step admits an infinite sequence of smaller steps below it. Zero is also a limit point there, but so is the 2-adic zero; the order is what decides.

Q_2 is not an exotic choice. Among all completions of the rationals, Ostrowski's theorem says there are exactly two kinds: Archimedean ones (like $\mathbb{R}$, which is densely ordered, so zero has no first step) and non-Archimedean ones ($\mathbb{Q}_p$, where the p-adic valuation assigns zero infinite valuation while every non-zero element has finite valuation). Q_2 is the non-Archimedean completion at $p = 2$, the minimum prime compatible with binary existence. The valuative distinction of zero is not imposed; it follows from the completion. The framework did not choose unusual mathematics for its own sake. It followed the result to the structure the result required.

A note on scope: ZP-F establishes this result for linearly ordered fields — the class that contains $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{Q}$ — because that is the natural comparison class for the most familiar number systems. The blocking phenomenon is not unique to fields: in any densely ordered structure no element has a first step (axb1_fails_everywhere_iff_dense). The ordered field result is the right frame for the $\mathbb{R}$ comparison. The broader phenomenon is the same.

Where the Snap Fails

The Binary Snap is impossible in $\mathbb{R}$: for any $\varepsilon_0 > 0$, $\varepsilon_0 / 2$ also exists; $\mathbb{R}$ is densely ordered, and in a dense order no element has a first step. Q_2 is not blocked that way. Its zero is distinguished in two charts: by its valuation, $v_2(0) = +\infty$ while every non-zero element carries a finite valuation, and as a limit the doubling orbit approaches and does not reach in finite time. Neither supplies the first step; that is AX-B1, a commitment.